PREFACE

IT'S BEEN THIRTY YEARS THAT I HAVE BEEN ASKING MYSELF WHETHER to write a book on the assassination of India's former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. It is during these three decades that friends, seniors and government officials have asked me why I have never thought of writing a book even after extensively covering one of the biggest crimes in modern Indian history for the *India Today* magazine. And when I finally did, the very first question my publisher asked me was why I wrote the book after all these years.

The story 'Rajiv Assassination: The Inside Story' on the 15 July 1991 issue of the *India Today* magazine had got people talking. While the general response was euphoric, a section of the media felt I was sensationalizing it. The truth is, I had suppressed much more information than I could and had revealed. By the time the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) filed the charge sheet, which was eleven months after the assassination, I had a surfeit of concealed facts: the former Prime Minister's assassination was the product of a conspiracy; the plotters and key operators came not just from the Tamil guerrilla separatist organization LTTE (the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam) but had links across the globe. And as the probe gained traction, followed by the seizure of incriminating documents and arrests made, Sivarasan emerged as the mastermind of the complex web that eventually took Rajiv Gandhi's life. It became evident that he was regularly in touch with contacts in Singapore, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Sweden, France and the UK before and after carrying out the assassination.

There have been many theories and conclusions, including the Supreme Court of India's verdict based on the findings of the CBI's special investigation team (SIT), upholding the death sentence awarded to the assassins. The number of death sentences awarded to the twenty-three accused in the Madras TADA (Terrorist and Disruptive Activities